

Overcrowding at Madrid, Barcelona airports prevents flight expansion

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【要点】

- ・マドリードとバルセロナの主要空港は、2027年夏のスケジュール期間から、ターミナル混雑のため、ピーク時の新規便追加を制限する。
- ・空港利用者数の増加がターミナル拡張能力を上回っており、この問題はヨーロッパ全域の他の空港にも広がると予想されている。
- ・スペイン国営空港運営会社AENAは、ターミナルごとおよび乗客タイプ別に乗客数の上限を設定し、ピーク時の便をオフピーク時にシフトさせる新システムを導入する予定である。
- ・これまでの容量制限は航空機の発着数に基づいていたが、新システムでは乗客数とシェンゲン域内外からの乗客区別も考慮される。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with TOMMASO LECCA SNEAK PEEK — Spain's two largest airports w

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By MARTINA SAPIO

with TOMMASO LECCA

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SNEAK PEEK

— Spain's two largest airports will curb growth during peak hours as passenger demand outpaces terminal capacity — a challenge the industry warns is spreading across Europe.

— Shipping is set to generate up to €9 billion a year in EU emissions trading revenues, but governments are failing to reinvest the money in the sector's green transition, European shipowners warn.

— Moscow's rail border closures in Finland and Estonia are causing little short-term disruption — but operators warn the real damage is the uncertainty for future freight corridors.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

MADRID, BARCELONA AIRPORT GROWTH TO BE CAPPED NEXT SUMMER: Airlines operating at Spain's two largest airports will be prevented from adding new flights during peak hours because of terminal congestion. Passenger numbers at Madrid-Barajas and Barcelona-El Prat are growing faster than the two hubs can expand their capacity, highlighting a problem the aviation sector expects to spread to other European airports.

The decision by Spanish airport operator AENA — first reported by El País — was taken “given the capacity constraints these facilities face during peak hours of the day,” the company confirmed in an emailed statement.

A long, constrained summer: The state-owned operator will present a plan introducing limits on “passenger numbers by terminal and type of traffic that can be handled at the airport terminals.” The measures will apply from the 2027 summer scheduling season — which, in aviation, runs from the last Sunday of March to the last Saturday of October. The aim is “to spread out the new slots from peak hours to off-peak hours,” adapting terminal capacity “without limiting their current capacity,” AENA said.

Passenger volume limits: The new system will affect “airlines that wish to expand operations at both airports during certain hours or months.” Until now, capacity constraints were based on aircraft movements, with Madrid handling up to 100 takeoffs or landings per hour and Barcelona up to 78, according to El País. From next summer, Aena will also set limits on passenger volumes by terminal and by traffic type, including whether passengers arrive from within or outside the Schengen area.

Victims of their own success: “The capacity constraints emerging at peak times in Madrid and Barcelona are first and foremost a reflection of Spain's exceptional post-pandemic success,” said Olivier Jankovec, director general of airport lobby ACI Europe. “Spain has been one of Europe's fastest-growing aviation markets, with demand recovering well beyond expectations.”

Bigger picture: But, Jankovec told Tommaso, “this is also part of a much wider European challenge” because “airport capacity is becoming an increasingly critical constraint across the continent.” As passenger numbers continue to rise, more airports may be forced to say “no, thanks” to additional flights, the industry fears.

“Eurocontrol estimates that, without additional airport capacity, Europe could lose around 1.1 million flights annually by 2050,” Jankovec said, warning of “significant consequences for connectivity, competitiveness and economic growth.”

An expensive solution: According to ACI Europe, the answer is more investment in airport infrastructure. “Across Europe, airports need to invest around €360 billion over the next two decades to expand capacity, modernize facilities, strengthen operational resilience and deliver decarbonization,” Jankovec said.

Who pays? “These investments are overwhelmingly financed by airports themselves under the long-established user-pays principle, without burdening taxpayers,” he added — meaning airlines and other airport users would ultimately bear the cost if they want additional capacity.

MARITIME

SHIPPING'S €9B REVENUE REINVESTMENT QUESTION: Shipping is set to generate up to €9 billion a year in EU emissions trading revenues, but European shipowners warn governments are failing to reinvest the money in the sector's green transition.

The numbers: A new analysis by the European Community Shipowners' Associations, shared with POLITICO ahead of its publication today, estimates shipping will contribute around €7.7 billion annually to national budgets and a further €1.3 billion to the EU Innovation Fund if carbon prices average €100 per ton. Even under a lower €85 carbon price scenario, the sector would still generate roughly €7.65 billion in annual ETS revenues.

The problem: According to the analysis, most member countries have yet to earmark any shipping ETS revenues for maritime decarbonization. The study also points to the Commission's latest Carbon Market Report, which found member countries invested only around 5 percent of overall ETS revenues in decarbonization measures in 2024.

Eyes on July 17: ECSA is urging the Commission to use the upcoming review of the EU Emissions Trading System to require member countries to dedicate at least part of shipping ETS revenues to the sector, including sustainable fuels and clean maritime technologies. The ETS revision is expected to be published on July 17.

The argument: "European shipowners are leading global investments in sustainable fuel-powered vessels, but Europe's investments in sustainable fuel availability and clean tech are not keeping pace," said ECSA Secretary-General Sotiris Raptis. "We need to see these revenues invested in the energy transition of the sector."

****What should we expect from this week's NATO summit? POLITICO's Jan Cieski, Megan Messerly and Esther Webber will unpack the stakes in Ankara, including Ukraine, Iran, Trump's relationship with European allies and the future of NATO itself. Join us online on July 6 at 4 p.m. CEST. Register here .****

RAIL

RUSSIA'S RAIL BORDER CLOSURE CASTS DOUBT OVER FREIGHT ROUTES: Russia's decision to suspend rail border crossings with Finland, Estonia and Latvia is expected to cause little immediate disruption, but transport authorities warn it creates fresh uncertainty for the future of cross-border freight and longer-term logistics planning.

Finland's view: Finland's Transport and Communications Agency told Martina the affected crossings on the Finnish side have been closed since December 2023, meaning the practical consequences are expected to be limited. Passenger rail services have been suspended since spring 2022, while freight continues only in small volumes. The agency said the immediate impact would be confined to a single railway undertaking.

Estonia reroutes: Estonia's state-owned rail infrastructure manager, Eesti Raudtee, told local media that two freight trains affected by the Russian decision have already been rerouted via the Narva rail crossing. Because the Narva and Koidula crossings are technically interchangeable, the company said it does not expect major operational disruption.

The bigger concern: While only very few freight trains cross Estonia's eastern rail border, Eesti Raudtee said that the greater challenge is the uncertainty created by sudden Russian decisions. Estonia has been working to expand rail freight links with Central Asia, and unpredictable border closures make long-term logistics planning significantly more difficult.

MILITARY MOBILITY

EU COUNTRIES PUSH BACK ON CYBER RULES FOR DUAL-USE INFRASTRUCTURE: EU governments are resisting Commission plans to extend the bloc's cybersecurity rules to dual-use infrastructure such as ports, roads and railways, warning the move could expose sensitive military information, our colleague Sam Clark reports.

Why it matters: The proposal would bring strategic dual-use infrastructure under the scope of the NIS2 Directive as part of the Commission's cybersecurity overhaul. For the transport sector, that could mean ports, railways and other infrastructure designated under the EU's Military Mobility Regulation becoming subject to new cybersecurity obligations.

The backlash: France described the proposal as "extremely premature," arguing it should not move ahead while negotiations on the Military Mobility Regulation are still underway. Paris also warned the rules could force member countries to share sensitive information about cyber incidents and critical infrastructure. Hungary, Spain, Austria, the Czech Republic and Lithuania also raised concerns, while Germany backed the proposal but called for exemptions for small businesses. Sam has more here .

PORTS

EES DOESN'T LOOK THE SAME EVERYWHERE: As airports warn of five-hour border queues and U.K. ports fears a summer "critical incident," other ports say the EU's new Entry/Exit System is having a far more limited operational impact.

A different picture: The Port of Antwerp-Bruges told Martina it is "prepared for the rollout of the EU Entry/Exit System" and does not expect major operational or infrastructure challenges. The port said the necessary infrastructure is already in place to handle passenger checks and the relatively small number of embarking and disembarking cruise passengers.

Why it matters: Antwerp said its role as a transit cruise port means EES has a much more limited operational impact than at airports, ferry terminals or cruise turnaround ports, where passengers begin or end their journeys. Even though passenger checks have become more frequent in recent years, the port noted, the existing infrastructure is sufficient to support those operations, leading it to conclude that no major disruption is expected.

Dover's warning: Across the Channel, the Port of Dover has urged the U.K. government to seek an agreement with France and the EU to suspend or scale back EES during the busiest summer periods. Port chief Doug Bannister warned that without greater flexibility, tourist traffic could back up for miles, trapping freight vehicles behind holidaymakers.

AVIATION

AIR PASSENGER RIGHTS REFORM AWAITS PARLIAMENT'S RUBBER STAMP: The long-awaited reform of EU air passenger rights will take center stage in a parliamentary debate in Strasbourg at 5:30 p.m. The text is due to be put to a plenary vote on Tuesday and, if approved, will be sent back to the Council for final adoption. Its provisions will enter into force one year after publication in the Official Journal of the EU.

COMMISSION SHIFTS TONE ON ENTRY/EXIT SYSTEM 'TECHNICAL PROBLEMS': After months of downplaying growing queues at EU airports following the introduction of the Entry/Exit System (EES), the Commission on Friday acknowledged problems with its implementation. The European Commission later said it will launch new talks with EU member countries as part of efforts to ensure the bloc's flagship new border checks system doesn't cause major delays for holidaymakers throughout the

summer, Gabriel Gavin reports .

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

EU pushes to beat airport delays caused by new biometric system

The new photo and fingerprint requirements are designed to stop criminals and visa overstayers — but they have left thousands stuck in line.

By Gabriel Gavin · Jul 05, 2026, 05:31 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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